

GILTEDGE

PRE DEPARTURE DOCUMENT

RWANDA



ESSENTIAL TRAVEL
INFORMATION

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We have put together a short guide with important information to ensure you have a wonderful stay in Rwanda.

[GILTEDGE Terms & Conditions](#)

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CONTACTS

Should you wish to contact us, please use the following details during office hours:

GILTEDGE (OFFICE HOURS: MONDAY TO FRIDAY 08H30 - 17H00):

Telephone (local):	+27 21 713 0296
Email:	info@gilt-edge.com
Website:	https://giltedge.travel/
Emergency Number:	+27 21 712 3915

For emergency assistance, please contact your African Travel Expert directly.
Their contact details can be found on the last page of your itinerary and in the Travel Key app.



PASSPORTS

- Your passport must be valid for at least **6 months**
 - Ensure you have at least **2 consecutive blank pages** (Endorsement pages do not qualify as blank pages)
 - Visiting **more than one country**? Aim for **2 side-by-side blank pages per country** to be safe.
-

VISA INFORMATION

Travellers require a visa to enter Rwanda.

Entry Requirements

- **Apply online** via the Online Portal:
https://irembo.gov.rw/user/citizen/service/dgie/request_a_visa
- Visas can also be **obtained on arrival** - ensure you have the exact amount in USD cash.
More information: <https://www.migration.gov.rw/>
- **Passport** valid for at least 6 months
- Proof of **sufficient funds** (min. USD 1000)
- Return or onward **ticket**
- **Documents for your next destination**, if applicable
- **Yellow Fever Vaccination Certificate**: Refer to page 10 for more information on this

Visa Prices

- **Single Entry Visa**: USD 50 (valid for 30 days)
- **Multiple Entry Visa**: USD 70 (valid for up to 90 days)

Special Exemptions

- Citizens of the **African Union**, **the Commonwealth** (including the UK, Australia, New Zealand), and **La Francophonie countries** (including Canada) receive a free 30-day visa upon arrival.

The East African Tourist Visa - <https://eastafricatourism.org/visa-information/>

- The East African Tourist Visa allows travellers to visit **Rwanda and Uganda under a single visa** for tourism purposes. (*Tanzania & Kenya are not included in this agreement.*)
- **Cost**: USD 100 per person
- **Validity**: Multiple entries for up to **90 days**
- Must be applied for in the **country of first arrival**
- Applications can be **submitted** at diplomatic representations of Rwanda or Uganda at immigration offices within these countries, or online.

Important:

- **Entry rules can change** - please confirm this with the embassy or consulate before travel. GILTEDGE cannot be held liable if entry is denied.
- GILTEDGE can assist with **visa services** at an additional cost. Chat to your African Travel Expert for more information.

BAGGAGE

Local & Regional Flights within East Africa:

- **Luggage allowances vary depending** on the airline - please check your flight ticket or ask your African Travel Expert for specific details.

Light Aircraft Flights (shuttle, charter, private):

- **Weight limit:** 15kg (33lbs) per person - includes all carry-on and camera gear
- **Bag size limit:** Small soft-sided bags only
- **No hard-shell cases** or rigid frames
- **Wheels are allowed only if** not part of a solid base
- **Tip:** Use a **fully soft-sided duffel-style bag** - it must be flexible enough to fit into compact luggage holds.
- **Excess baggage** will incur an additional charge



Plastic

- In Akagera National Park, **single-use plastics** are banned.
- **Refrain from carrying disposable plastic bags or Ziploc bags** in your main or hand luggage to avoid inconvenience on arrival.

SHOPPING

Rwanda offers a **treasure trove of authentic East African goods** - from intricate beadwork and colourful fabrics to stunning wood carvings, jewellery, coffee, tea, modern art, and much more.

Where to Shop:

- **Gift shops** in hotels and lodges (fixed prices, good quality)
- **Local markets and craft stalls** (perfect for bargain hunters)

Bargaining Tips:

- **Bartering is part of the culture** and expected in markets!
- **Starting prices** are usually high, so feel free to **negotiate respectfully**
- If you're **short on time** or patience, politely offer your **"final price"**
- If you're unsure of anything, ask your **guide for assistance**

 **Remember:** Handmade items like carvings and beadwork take time and skill - fair prices support local artisans.

CLIMATE

-  **Dry Seasons**
 - **June-September & December-February** - Warm, sunny days and cooler nights
-  **Rainy Seasons:**
 - **Long rains (March - May)** - Showers usually come in the afternoon or evening, with warm, humid conditions during the day
 - **Short rains (October - November)** - Lighter, shorter, and more scattered with greener landscapes and humid conditions

ELECTRICITY

Rwanda uses plug **types C and J**:

- **Type C**: two round pins
- **Type J**: three round pins

The electricity supply is 230V / 50Hz.

✓ Tip: Bring a **universal travel adapter** & **power bank** to stay connected throughout your trip!

COMMUNICATION

- **Mobile networks** are generally reliable in towns and major parks
- **SIM cards** with data are affordable and easy to purchase locally
- **Wi-Fi is available at most lodges and hotels**, but may be limited or slow in remote areas.

LANGUAGE

- **Kinyarwanda, French, English & Swahili** are the official languages of Rwanda

TIME ZONE



Rwanda uses **East Africa Time (EAT)**, which is 3 hours ahead of Greenwich Mean Time (GMT+3). The country does not observe daylight saving time.

CURRENCY

💰 Currency:

- Rwandan Franc (**RWF / RF**)
- Bring **US dollars or Euros** in cash to exchange on arrival
- **Exchange** at the airport, banks, or Foreign Exchange Bureau

🏠 Banking & Cards

- **ATMs** are available in Kigali and major towns
- Credit cards (Visa/Mastercard) are widely accepted in most **hotels, lodges and restaurants**

CLOTHING

Modest clothing is advised, especially in **rural areas**.

👕 General

- Comfortable **casual wear** for travel days
- **Sleepwear**

🦒 Safari Packing List

- Lightweight, **neutral-coloured clothes** (long sleeves for sun/bugs)
- **Light fleece** or jacket for cool evenings
- **Swimwear**
- **Raincoat** or windbreaker
- **Scarf/buff**,
- Comfortable **walking shoes** + boots and socks
- Sun hat, **sunglasses** & **sunscreen**
- Insect **repellent** & **malaria tablets** (per doctor's advice)
- Small **daypack** for water, snacks & layers
- **Binoculars** & camera (extra memory cards, charger)
- Avoid **white, bright colours, and especially blue** - it attracts tsetse flies!



🦍 Gorilla Trekking & 🏔 Mountain Climbing

- Sturdy, **waterproof hiking boots** (well broken-in)
- The Virunga Mountains can be colder - **pack warm layers**
- **Long trousers & long-sleeve shirts** (tuck into socks for ants)
- **Hiking/gardening gloves** for grip & nettle protection
- Extra pairs of thick, **moisture-wicking socks**
- Lightweight **rain jacket** or poncho
- **Hat** (sun or rain protection)
- Small **backpack** for water, snacks & rain gear
- **Gaiters** or tape to keep ants/mud out of boots
- Reusable **water bottle/hydration pack** + energy snacks
- Insect **repellent** & **sunscreen**
- **Facemask** (for gorilla health protection)
- **Optional:** trekking poles for steep/muddy trails

💡 Tip: Bring **layers** to stay comfortable as temperatures can vary by region and time of year!

🪥 **Laundry** is available at most hotels and lodges (but avoid sending anything delicate).

GORILLA TREKKING

✓ Who Can Trek?

- **Minimum age:** 15 years
- Must be **fit and in good health**
- Gorilla trekking can be physically demanding, especially at **high altitudes**. If you have **any medical conditions** that could be affected by strenuous activity, we **strongly recommend** checking in with **your doctor** well before your trip
- **Sightings can be influenced by factors** such as weather and tracking conditions. However, gorilla trekking proceeds regardless of the weather

📄 Permits

- **Limited permits available** - book well in advance
- Must be **paid at the time of safari booking** to secure your place
- **Non-refundable**, unless cancelled for medical reasons (certificate required)
- A portion of the fee supports **local communities**

📋 Trekking Rules

- Max **1 hour** viewing per group
- Max **8 guests per trek**
- Maintain a **7-metre (23-foot) distance** from the gorillas
- **Always wash your hands** before heading out to see the gorillas
- **Face masks** are required
- No **eating, drinking, smoking, littering** or **spitting** during the trek
- No **flash photography** is allowed
- Keep **voices low** and **movements calm**
- **Guests showing symptoms** of a cold, flu, or other respiratory infections will not be permitted to join the trek
- If you need to **sneeze or cough**, turn away and cover your mouth
- If a **gorilla charges or vocalises**, do not be alarmed. Stand still, look away from the gorilla and follow your guide's instructions



DRINKING WATER

✗💧 The golden rule: avoid tap water and ice

- Stick to **sealed bottled water** or drinks from trusted brands
- Use water only from containers with serrated **safety seals** or from lodges with proper filtration systems
- **Bottled water is widely available**



GRATUITIES | TIPPING

💰 **Tipping is not mandatory** but is **highly appreciated**. Here's a general **guideline**:

✈️ Airport & Transfers

- **Airport Meet & Assist**: USD 10 per meet & assist
- **Drivers/Guides**: USD 15 per group, per transfer
- **Transfer Drivers**: USD 10 per group, per transfer
- **Baggage Porters (lodges/airports)**: USD 5 per person

🏠 Lodges & Camps

- **Lodge Ranger/Guide**: USD 30 per room, per day (USD 15 per person)
- **Lodge Tracker**: USD 20 per room, per day
- **General Camp Staff / Butlers**: USD 25 per room, per day (pooled among housekeepers, waiters, bartenders, etc.)

🧑 Private Guides

- USD 10-15 per person for a **half-day**
- USD 15-20 per person for a **full day**
- **Tip at the end** if with you for multiple days

🍴 Restaurants & Services

- **Restaurants**: 10-15% of the bill
- **Massage Therapists**: 10% of the bill

🧑 Gorilla Trekking Team

(Minimum customary guideline - increase if service is exceptional, as this directly supports communities & conservation)

- **Head Ranger / Park Guides**: USD 20 per person, per trek (usually two guides; tip at the end of each trek)
- **Porters**: USD 15 per person, per day
- **Trackers**: USD 15 per person, per trek (tipped separately before returning to headquarters)
- **Security Personnel**: USD 10 per person, per day

👉 **Suggestion**: Give tips for the Head Ranger, Porters, and Security personnel directly to the Head Ranger (they will distribute fairly). Tip trackers separately, since they do not return with the group to the National Park Headquarters.



HEALTH

Medication & Essentials

- Bring enough of your **prescription meds** for the entire trip
- Include a **copy of your prescription and your doctor's contact information**

Malaria

- Rwanda is a **malaria area**
- **Anti-malarial medication** is recommended (consult your doctor)
- **Wear long sleeves & pants** in the evenings
- Use insect **repellent** & sleep under a **mosquito net**

Sun Safety

- The sun is intense - **sunburn and sunstroke** are common
- Use high-factor **sunscreen**, wear a **hat**, and **stay hydrated**

Yellow Fever Vaccination Certificate

- Rwanda is considered a **yellow fever risk area**
- **Please consult your doctor** to discuss yellow fever risks and vaccination requirements
- You may be required to show **proof of a yellow fever vaccination** when travelling to your next destination or returning to your home country

Altitude Sickness

- Travelling to higher altitudes (e.g. gorilla trekking or mountain climbing) can cause **Acute Mountain Sickness (AMS)**.
- **Symptoms** may include shortness of breath, fatigue, headaches, and nausea.
- The higher you go, **the greater the chance of feeling the effects**, as the air gets thinner.
- **Physical fitness** does not guarantee prevention.

How to Feel Better at High Altitudes:

- **Rest on your first day**; avoid strenuous activity
- Drink at least **3 litres of water** daily
- **Limit alcohol** (it dehydrates and worsens symptoms)
- **Eat plenty of carbs** to help your body adjust
- Bring the **necessary medication** to manage headaches

✓ **Tip:** Always check the **latest advice with your travel clinic or doctor** at least 4-6 weeks before departure.

For the latest health info:

<https://wwwnc.cdc.gov/travel/destinations/traveler/none/rwanda>



SAFETY

Rwanda is a **welcoming and unforgettable destination**, but as with anywhere, **staying alert** and prepared helps keep your trip smooth and **stress-free**.

Personal Safety Tips

- **Leave valuables** (jewellery, extra cash, passport) in your **hotel safe**
- **Carry only what you need** for the day
- **Avoid flashing** mobile devices or cameras in public
- **Don't walk alone at night**, especially in city centres

Safari Safety

- Many lodges are **unfenced** - wildlife may wander through
- **Never walk alone**, especially after dark
- **Always follow instructions** from your safari guide
- **Observe animals quietly** and from a safe distance

Travel Documents

- **Make two copies of all important documents** (passport, cards, insurance)
- **Keep one copy with you** (separate from the originals) and **leave another at home**
- **Memorise key information** like passport and credit card numbers, just in case

Travel Insurance

- **Comprehensive** travel insurance is essential
- Should include **emergency evacuation** and **airlift cover**
- Purchase it within **21 days of your initial trip** deposit to cover pre-existing conditions

PHOTOGRAPHY

- **Always ask permission** before photographing people
- Do not photograph **military personnel or government buildings**
- **No flash photography** near gorillas or chimpanzees
- Bring **weatherproof** camera gear - conditions can be humid with sudden rain
- Filming in National Parks requires a **permit** - apply in advance if needed



NOTE



Please chat to your African Travel Expert if you are unsure of anything

This guide was compiled in good faith and reflects information accurate at the time of publication (November 2025). If you come across any updates or changes, we would appreciate your feedback to help us keep this guide current.

*We wish you an unforgettable
African experience!*

LET'S STAY IN TOUCH

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